



BHASKAR PAUL

MUMBAI IS GOING THE DELHI WAY WITH CHECKPOSTS AND ARMED SECURITY PERSONNEL BECOMING COMMONPLACE

nine officers trained in combat. These vehicles will be equipped with a bulletproof cover, bulletproof vests and helmets. Apart from this, there will be five regional control rooms with 100 people each on call 24x7. These teams will be the first responders in case of an attack. The commissioner's control room is also being upgraded at the cost of Rs 2.5 crore, in a manner that the office will be able to monitor and get real-time information from different parts of the city. The personnel manning the control room will be trained to sift through information and analyse it correctly.

One of the most ambitious ventures of the department seeks to link all surveillance cameras and other equipment on a common platform, such that all the feeds come into a common con-

trol room. Specialised manpower will be required to man the control room. Explains Iyengar, "The IT team is looking into how this can be done, but we want to link all the surveillance systems across the city so that it can be monitored from one place. This requires purchase of equipment, construction and telecom links, all of which are being worked upon."

The creation of Force One was supposed to act as the city's crack combat force, however, this force is nowhere near ready. While the sanctioned strength is 352, the fighting unit comprises 256 persons. The entire team is undergoing training, which will end in October this year. Says a senior government official: "It would not be correct to expect that boys who have been trained for three months become an

active combative force immediately. Neither the army nor the National Security Guard were formed in a year."

Apart from waking up to new realities of the pathetic security levels in the city, 26/11 has forced the Home Department to decentralise its powers. One of the biggest cribs that IPS officers have pertains to their reporting structure. All powers are centralised and the DGP cannot act on anything without the permission of the home secretary, who is an IAS officer. Putting an end to this, Iyengar has devolved promotion and purchasing powers to the DGP's office. For the first time, the DGP has promoted and transferred officers of the inspector and sub-inspector ranks.

Giving purchasing powers to the DGP's office is another step in that direction. In order to prevent acquisition of